9.1 Family line of Konoe and Sutoku.

This put Sutoku in exactly the same position Toba had occupied, all those years: junior Cloistered Emperor, powerless, resentful. Given the various hatreds and ambitions flying around the court, it is perhaps surprising that Konoe lasted thirteen years before someone slipped poison into his food.

At Konoe's death, in 1155, Toba proposed that his next son (barring Sutoku, of course) become the new emperor; Sutoku objected, proposing either himself or his own oldest son as the logical candidate. Toba, who had more soldiers, won the argument; his son Go-Shirakawa ("Shirakawa the Second") became the new emperor, and peace briefly descended on the royal house. "While Toba was alive," the *Gukansho* tells us, "no rebellions or wars broke out."[7]

But Toba died barely a year later. Before his funeral had even ended, the courtiers, clan leaders, and samurai were lining up behind the rival brothers, Go-Shirakawa and Sutoku had commandeered two different royal palaces to use as their respective headquarters, and the capital city was preparing for war.

The sides did not break neatly along clan lines. Taira and Minamoto clan members could be found in both armies, as could Fujiwara officials. Sutoku's right-hand commander was the Minamoto clan leader Tameyoshi, accompanied by his son Tametomo. In *The Tale of Hogen*, an account of the struggle written in the early fourteenth century, Tametomo is a superhero, more than seven feet tall: "Born to archery, he had a bow arm that was some six inches longer than the arm with which he held his horse's reins . . . [and he used] a bow that was more than eight and a half feet in length." Tametomo's skill was restricted, though, by the presence of his brother Yoshitomo on the other side; Yoshitomo had been one of the first courtiers to declare himself a supporter of Go-Shirakawa, and had put four hundred hand-chosen samurai warriors at the emperor's disposal.[8]

The two sides finally met in battle on the night of July 29, 1156, in a brief and violent clash known afterwards as the Hogen Incident.* Tametomo picked off a number of warriors on the opposing side, but his brother Yoshitomo had the brilliant idea of sending an arsonist in to set Sutoko's headquarters on fire. As the Cloistered Emperor's men scrambled away from the flames, Go-Shirakawa's archers took them down, one at a time. "Those who were afraid of the arrows and terrified by the flames even jumped into the wells in large numbers," the *Tale of Hogen* says, "and of these, too, the bottom ones in a short time had drowned, those in the middle had been crushed to death by their fellows, and those on top had been burned up by the